



Black-shirted paramilitaries of Oswald Mosley's British Union of Fascists give the Nazi salute. Mosley was inspired by the example of Mussolini and Hitler.

IN A YEAR DOMINATED BY POLITICAL VIOLENCE and assassinations, the **French Third Republic** was rocked by the **Stavisky affair**. A crooked financier, Alexandre Stavisky committed suicide on January 8, after the collapse of a dishonest investment scheme. The right-wing press accused leading French politicians of profiting from Stavisky's fraudulent deals. On February 6, various nationalist and anti-Semitic groups assembled in Paris, intending to march on the Chamber of

Deputies and overthrow the allegedly corrupt Republic. In a night of **street fighting** between thousands of demonstrators and police, 15 people were killed and many more injured. The attempt to force the government to resign failed, and the **Republic survived**.

In the US, the public was distracted from the woes of the **Depression** by the exploits and violent deaths of outlaws and gangsters. **Bonnie Parker** and **Clyde Barrow** led a gang that robbed banks, stores, and gas stations, roving from Texas to Minnesota. Their shoot-outs with police and narrow escapes were reported with feverish excitement in the press. Parker and Barrow were finally **ambushed and shot dead** by police at Bienville Parish, Louisiana, on May 23, 1934, sealing the legend of "Bonnie and Clyde." Another "most wanted" criminal was the



Bonnie and Clyde
American outlaw Bonnie Parker playfully targets her partner-in-crime Clyde Barrow. This photo was on a reel of film found by police in 1933.

“VERY FEW OF THESE PANIC-MONGERS HAVE ANY PERSONAL KNOWLEDGE OF THE COUNTRIES THAT ARE ALREADY UNDER BLACKSHIRT GOVERNMENT.”

Lord Rothermere, *Daily Mirror*, January 22, 1934

gangster **John Dillinger**. Arrested in January, he escaped from custody, but was tracked down by federal investigation chief J. Edgar Hoover. On July 22, Dillinger was gunned down by federal agents as he left the Biograph Theater, a movie house in Chicago.

Another man to die by the bullet in 1934 was **Sergei Kirov**, the Communist Party boss in Leningrad and a close associate of Soviet dictator **Joseph Stalin**. On December 1, a man walked up behind Kirov in a corridor outside his office and shot him in the back of the neck. The **assassination** was blamed on Leonid Nikolaev, an expelled party member with a grudge, but suspicions persist that Stalin may have arranged the assassination himself. Whatever the truth, the Soviet dictator used Kirov's death to pass a **new antiterrorist law**, which was later used to justify the **arrest and execution** of hundreds of thousands of people.

In Germany, on June 30–July 1, Adolf Hitler confirmed his hold on power by a massacre, known as the **Night of the Long Knives**. The main target of the killings was the leadership of the SA (Sturmabteilung or Stormtroopers). These paramilitaries had provided the muscle for Hitler's rise to power, but now the disorderly street-fighters had become an embarrassment. SA chief **Ernst Röhm** was one of the hundreds that were killed. He was **arrested** early on the morning of July 1 by Hitler, who was accompanied by SS guards. Röhm was asked to

kill himself, but refused and was **shot without trial** by the leader of the SS, Theodor Eicke. As well as the SA leadership, scores of individuals who had criticized the Nazi regime were also murdered.

In **Austria**, a Nazi attempt to seize power failed. The Austrian chancellor **Engelbert Dollfuss** had established an authoritarian single-party state. In February, Dollfuss suppressed a left-wing uprising in Vienna, using artillery against the socialists' stronghold in the Karl Marx Hof housing estate. He also banned the Austrian Nazi Party. In July, the Nazis attempted an armed coup, probably intending to achieve the unification of Austria with Nazi Germany. Although Dollfuss was killed, the coup failed. **Kurt Schuschnigg**, a member of Dollfuss's party, succeeded him as chancellor.

Britain was a relative haven of tranquility, but even there **fascism** was on the rise. Former Labour minister Oswald Mosley had founded the **British Union of Fascists** (BUF) in 1932, hoping to turn Britain into an authoritarian state under his rule. In June 1934, Mosley staged a rally at Olympia in London that degenerated into a brawl as BUF paramilitaries fought with anti-fascist protestors. Such political violence had little appeal for the British, who were also alienated by the fascists' links with the Nazis—Hitler was a guest at Mosley's wedding. Although it enjoyed the backing of some national newspapers, the BUF remained a minority party without significant electoral support.



Ethiopian tribal warriors gather to fight for their emperor, Haile Selassie.

THROUGH THE FIRST HALF OF THE 1930S, parts of the US and Canada were swept by giant dust storms as topsoil blew off land ruined by a combination of persistent drought and intensive farming. The worst of these "**black blizzards**" occurred in April 1935, affecting a vast area of the plains of Kansas, Oklahoma, Texas, New Mexico, and Colorado. The **Dust Bowl** created by this

850 MILLION TONS
THE ESTIMATED AMOUNT OF TOPSOIL BLOWN OFF THE SOUTHERN PLAINS OF THE US BY DECEMBER 1935

ecological disaster could no longer support small farmers, who were forced to migrate in their thousands. Many of them found their way to migrant camps in California, where they were exploited as seasonal labor.

Meanwhile, President Roosevelt's administration was pressing ahead with a raft of reforms often referred to as the **Second New Deal**. These policies were more radical than

January 8 Death of financier Alexander Stavisky precipitates political crisis in France

February 6-7 Right-wing extremists attempt coup in Paris

February 21 Nicaraguan guerrilla leader Augusto Sandino assassinated

June 29-30 Hitler has many opponents murdered on Night of the Long Knives in Germany

July 25 In Austria, Dollfuss killed but attempted Nazi seizure of power fails

August 2 German president Hindenburg dies, opening way for Hitler to become Führer

October 9 King Alexander of Yugoslavia assassinated on state visit to France

December 1 Stalin's associate Sergei Kirov assassinated in Leningrad

December 19 Japan renounces Washington Treaties limiting naval armaments

January 13 Saarland chooses to become part of Germany

March 16 Hitler introduces conspiracy in open defiance of Versailles Treaty

January 17 Leading Soviet communists, including Kameney and Zinoviev, convicted of complicity in Kirov's murder

October 16 Chinese communists retreat from Jiangxi province, begin Long March

December 1 Lázaro Cárdenas becomes president of Mexico

October 6 Uprisings in Asturias and Catalonia shake Spanish Republic

July 30 Kurt Schuschnigg becomes chancellor of Austria

July 22 US gangster John Dillinger mortally wounded by police in Chicago

March 24 Degree of self-government for US-controlled Philippines

February 1 Austrian Chancellor Dollfuss bans all political parties except his own Fatherland Front